

Strider's Report - Recovery of our Fallen Striders

Party: Ruby (me), Achillea, Koté, Necro

Objective: Recover the bodies of our fallen Striders and, if possible, Atlas.

Setting Out

I met up with Achillea, Koté and Necro for what was easily one of the least cheerful expeditions I've been on.

Necro made it very clear he wasn't interested in recovering our younger colleagues. His only concern was finding Atlas' book. As I figured out from recent visits, someone called the Neverqueen told him to retrieve it. I still don't know who that is, but I don't like it, whether real or made up it's unsettling.

The journey itself was fairly uneventful at first. Necro spent most of it staring at and collecting insects instead of talking to people.

We eventually made camp beside a large termite nest... what a coincidence thanks Necro.

As if by fate, Achillea somehow found an anteater wandering nearby that happily helped lessen our little termite problem.

During the night, a single ivory-colored feather drifted down from above. I took a closer look and I'm fairly certain it wasn't from this plane.

Into the Mist

The following day we entered a forest covered in thick fog.

Eventually we spotted several large figures moving through the mist. They turned out to be mist elementals. They spoke Celestial. I recognized the language but sadly couldn't understand any of it. Thankfully Koté translated for us.

The elementals guided us to an enormous jackalope. A giant rabbit with antlers.

It introduced itself by saying it would lead us along the same path our "failures" had taken. Calling our colleagues failures who is he to judge. I already don't like him, but if it can bring us to their bodies I will do what I must.

The Divine Path

The jackalope led us for hours through twisting paths that made absolutely no sense. Every attempt to convince it to simply lead us directly to its master was met with the exact same answer.

"I said I would lead you down the path they took."

Nothing more. Nothing less.

Whenever we tried resting or stepping away from the flower-covered path, waves of psychic energy struck us and compelled us to continue walking.

At first, we believed this was some sort of trial. Endure long enough and perhaps we'd be rewarded.

Eventually it became painfully obvious what that reward likely was. Getting a little closer to its god. Which, judging by the bodies we'd already failed to find...

...probably meant dying.

We eventually decided we'd had enough. We killed the oversized zealot rabbit.

The psychic attacks returned when we first stepped off the path, but once we stayed away from it, they stopped completely.

It was a trick or at least a cruel test, perhaps we would have been rewarded. But more likely than not we would not have arrived at our destination. Zealot f--k.

Don't stay on the path!

Necro of all people somehow had a moment of sanity and plotted our direction to walk in calculating the Jackalope's twists and turns to figure out the way to go.

And as if reading my thoughts immediately started spewing something about always killing the rabbits... including Harengon's.

What I learned from this is to never trust Necro... even though he was right this time.

We eventually found the bodies of 3 striders, later identifying them as Ber, Ado and Xanaleth their fourth party member seemingly nowhere to be found. I look a bit further and found the body of orchid.

We trusted Necro to perform gentle repose on them. We head back and deliver their bodies to Haven.

Recovering Atlas

Our second objective was Atlas.

Koté led us back to the cave where they were ambushed and he had fallen.

An Alarm spell had been placed near the entrance, but I managed to dispel it before we entered unnoticed. Inside were several meenlocks, a druid and Atlas.

Or at least what remained of him.

He barely resembled the person I remembered.

Parts of his body had hardened into something like a carapace. His posture had become hunched. One eye had lost all color while the other oozed slime. His clothes were little more than rags. Whatever happened to him... It wasn't quick. (I'm sorry friend.)

Surprisingly they didn't put up a huge fight, and we quickly made short work of them. Koté wiping up a giant storm spell to finish off all the enemies... with the sole exception of Atlas of course. Necro killed Atlas's controlled body and we brought him home too, unfortunately he won't be coming back.

Seeing that this journey over the past days has taken not only a physical but also an emotional toll on us. We decide to leave our revenge on the backstreet barons for another time.

Notes for Future Striders

- The mist elementals are not immediately hostile. (This might have changed with the death of the Jackalope so be on edge.)
- If another should appear do not trust the jackalope's "Divine Path."
- If the path starts forcing you forward, leave it.



map)

(Credits to Luca for this